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VENTURE



**Index Ventures' Jaharvi
Sardana shares the truth
about TAM and what
founders should focus on
instead**

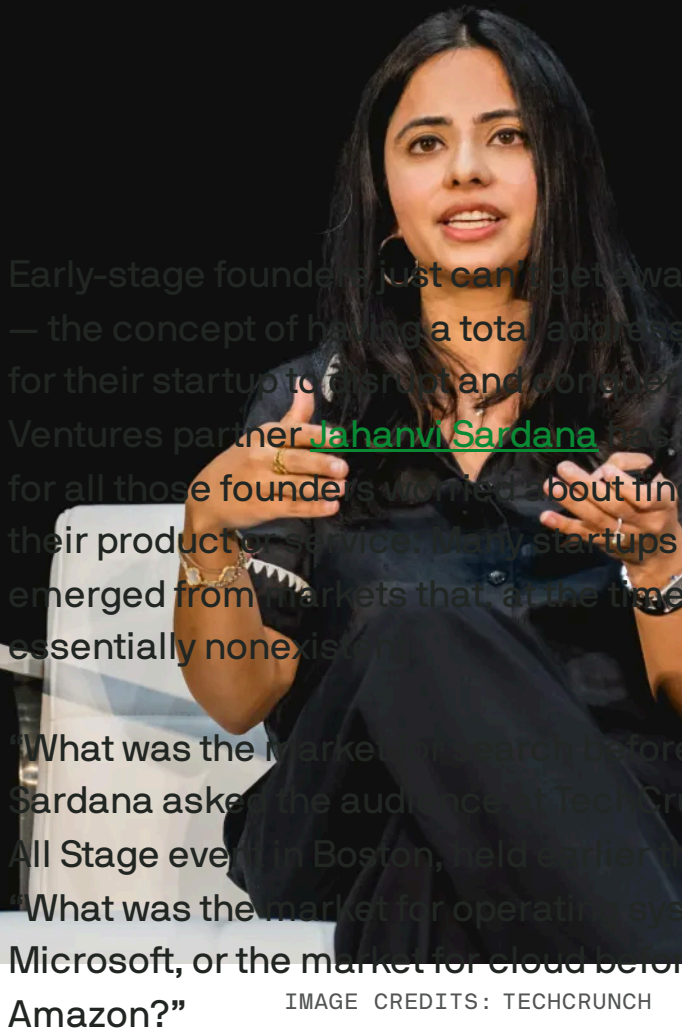


IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Early-stage founders just can't get away from TAM — the concept of having a total addressable market for their startup to disrupt and conquer. But Index Ventures partner [Jahanvi Sardana](#) has a reminder for all those founders worried about finding TAM for their product or service: Many startups have emerged from markets that, at the time, were essentially nonexistent.

“What was the market for search before Google?” Sardana asked the audience at TechCrunch's 2025 All Stage event in Boston, held earlier this month. “What was the market for operating systems before Microsoft, or the market for cloud before Amazon?”

Sardana compares TAM to surfing. Every few years, there are massive waves founders must ride — first came the internet, then the mobile wave, then the cloud, and now, she said, the biggest wave of all: artificial intelligence.

“Have you shaped the right product to ride this wave?” she continued. “That’s what we call product-market fit.”

Which TAM bucket are you in?

Sardana places TAM into three buckets: known market, emerging market, and invisible market.

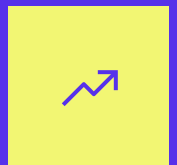
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The first, known market, already exists, and it is when a founder seeks to replace a legacy incumbent and must prove to an investor why their startup idea is better.



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“Everyone brushes their teeth,” she said. “You have to tell me why you’re building a better toothbrush.”

The emerging market is when a certain sector of the market is using a product, and there is potential for it to go mainstream.

“Think about non-alcoholic beer before it became cool,” Sardana said.

Then there is the invisible market, which Sardana calls “the biggest trap,” and “also a little bit of a dark art.”

The market doesn’t exist, and a founder has to essentially create one and provide investors with evidence of how innovative they can be.

“Think about smartphones in 2006; nobody knew they wanted them and they changed the world,” she said, later adding that “people don’t know what they’re looking for and sometimes you have to show them what’s possible.”

The audience at All Stage, many of whom are early-stage founders, peppered Sardana with questions, largely about what investors want to see. For instance, do investors want to see a TAM slide in a pitch deck?

“It’s OK to create that slide and talk about the math behind your TAM,” Sardana said, though she added that sometimes investors get annoyed when founders rely too much on industry metrics rather than having their own unique insight. Sardana also cautioned founders not to rely too much on industry reports. If a founder is too dependent on an external service to dictate how they think about the market, it can signal that they haven’t thought deeply about the market they are trying to build in, she commented.

“How do you size the TAM in the marketplaces, especially big marketplaces?” one audience member asked.

“Well, that question hurts,” Sardana quipped. After all, Index once passed on Airbnb, having believed its TAM was too small.

“The reality is Airbnb created a whole new inventory, which is now bigger than some of the largest hotel brands, and that led to a big change in behavior on how people travel,” she said, adding that marketplace TAMs are tricky. “You want to focus on, again, what is unlocking supply, and once you unlock the supply, how will behavior change?”

The audience also asked Sardana what makes a company stand out to an investor like herself.

A tough one, Sardana said, but a really important one. Ultimately, if a founder can understand who the customer is and why they are willing to purchase their product, then a company should have no problem standing up to investors, she added.

“We’re in the business of evaluating founders more than markets or products or anything else,” she said. “When you talk about your market, it’s really a lens on your ambition.”

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Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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STARTUPS



At TechCrunch All Stage, Jaharvi Sardana shares how top startups reshape markets

TechCrunch Events — 3:44 PM PDT · June 26, 2025



TechCrunch All Stage — the ultimate founder summit — is shaping up to be a powerhouse event where 1,200 founders and VCs across all stages will come together to forge meaningful connections and gain practical insights they can immediately apply to scale their startups. Join us on July 15 at SoWa Power Station in Boston and be part of the conversation with scaling experts.

IMAGE CREDITS: HALO CREATIVE

And now is the best time to register to attend. For a limited time, **we're dropping Investor Passes to just \$250 and Founder Passes to just \$155**, both more than 60% off their regular price. And those discounts deepen when you register for a group of four or more. **Act now before the cost of access to founders and VCs** from Boston and beyond jumps back up!

About the breakout session

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JAHANVI SARDANA

Partner,
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Adding even more value to this already-packed agenda, we're excited to announce that Jahanvi Sardana, partner at [Index Ventures](#), has joined the breakout session lineup. Sardana will dive into the critical elements of assessing total addressable market (TAM), revealing how the best startups don't just size markets — they create them.

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As a B2B investor, [Jahanvi Sardana](#) specializes in cybersecurity, enterprise software, and fintech, investing across seed to pre-IPO stages. She thrives on partnering with founders who embody grit — the secret ingredient that sets high performers apart. It's the perfect mix of passion, persistence, and stamina that turns visionary ideas into reality.

Prior to Index Ventures, Jahanvi was at Stripes, a growth equity firm in New York, where she focused on cybersecurity, fintech, and SaaS investments. Her career began in private equity at Aquiline Capital Partners.



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Unlock must-know strategies for startup success

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STARTUPS

TechCrunch All Stage: Full agenda revealed

TechCrunch Events — 7:58 AM PDT · April 16, 2025

The [ultimate founder summit](#) returns — now bigger than ever! Formerly TechCrunch Early Stage, TC All

Stage is bringing together founders and VCs from every stage, not just early stage.

We're thrilled to unveil the full breakout session lineup at [TC All Stage](#). Packed with scaling pioneers and top-tier VCs, these sessions are designed for founders and startups at every stage — covering everything from fundraising strategies to scaling operations. Join 1,200+ founders and VCs on July 15 in Boston to navigate the startup landscape together.

Stay tuned for the full list of interactive roundtable sessions — coming soon on [the agenda page](#)! Curious who's leading the breakouts? Head to the [speaker page](#) to get to know all our speakers.

Reserve your ticket now to guarantee access to a day of insights, connections, and inspiration. [Register now to save up to \\$210 on your ticket.](#)

Foundation Stage



Just getting started on your startup journey? The Foundation Stage is your launchpad — packed with practical skills to help you build and grow from day one.

All the Ways You Don't Realize VCs Are Evaluating Your Company at Pre-Seed

[Charles Hudson](#), Founder and Managing Partner, Precursor

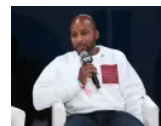
This is an important topic, especially for pre-seed founders, because much of company evaluation is about the founder and the idea — there isn't a lot of data to work with yet! One key point to highlight is

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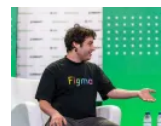


How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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Rebecca Bellan,
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Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis

- 16 hours ago

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that your choice of co-founder is critical. If it seems like you're not the best match, many VCs will use that as a proxy for your ability to hire strong talent. Additionally, there are numerous traps that founders fall into that indicate to VCs they've not learned how to run a fundraising process, so it's essential to do your homework in advance.



IMAGE CREDITS:HAJE KAMPS/TECHCRUNCH

MVP in the Age of AI: When to Bot and When to Not

[Chris Gardner](#), Partner, Underscore VC



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In an era where AI tools are revolutionizing how founders build software and prototypes, understanding both the opportunities and limitations is crucial for success. Join us to discover how AI is turbocharging MVP (minimum viable product) development and where some founders get it wrong by letting the robots do all the thinking. Learn the art of combining AI superpowers with irreplaceable human skills — nobody wants marketing copy that sounds like it was written by a very enthusiastic toaster! This session is perfect for founders navigating the wild world of building products in the age of AI.

The TAM Myth: How the Best Startups Reshape Markets

Jahanvi Sardana, Partner, Index Ventures

This session will dive into critical elements of assessing total addressable market (TAM). [Jahanvi Sardana](#), partner at Index Ventures, will explore

how the best startups don't just size markets — they create them. Through case studies from high-growth companies like Datadog, Adyen, Wiz, Shopify, and Airbnb, she will examine how they identified emerging trends, removed friction, and expanded their TAM beyond initial expectations. A must-attend for founders looking to build companies that define the future of their industries.

Crafting the Perfect VC Pitch: Luck Meets Strategy

Tiffany Luck, Partner, NEA

Join [Tiffany Luck](#) from NEA as she unveils the art of pitching to venture capitalists. In this dynamic session, you'll learn how to effectively convey your passion and vision, streamline your presentation to spotlight the elements that excite investors, and avoid common pitfalls that derail pitches. Tiffany will share insider tips on what VCs truly value, empowering you to tell your story with clarity and impact. Walk away with actionable strategies to captivate investors and secure the funding you need to propel your startup forward.

So You Think You Can Pitch?

Please join us for “So You Think You Can Pitch,” where three promising early-stage startups will have four minutes to wow a panel of judges, who will then provide feedback.

Scale Stage

Ready to level up? The Scale Stage offers growth-stage founders actionable insights to take their startups to the next level.

The New Rules of Growth-Stage Fundraising: How to Win at Raising a Series C & Beyond

Cathy Gao, Partner, Sapphire Ventures

After two years of decline, growth-stage fundraising is heating up again — driven largely by the surge of generative AI adoption. For most founders, breaking through the noise and securing top-tier investors is harder than ever. [Cathy Gao](#) from Sapphire Ventures will share what it really takes to raise a successful Series C+ in today's competitive environment. Whether you're scaling a breakout AI company or navigating the new fundraising landscape, this session will give you the insights to sharpen your pitch and maximize your fundraising outcomes.

The Operator's Playbook for Building and Scaling Sustainable Companies

Jon McNeill, CEO and Co-Founder, DVx Ventures

Most startups chase product-market fit but ignore a scalable go-to-market strategy, leading to premature scaling and failure. [Jon McNeill](#), former president of Tesla, COO of Lyft, and CEO and co-founder of hatch platform DVx Partners, suggests breaking the traditional VC mold by validating both before accelerating growth. The next wave of disruptive companies should be operator-driven and built for profitability and impact from day one. Jon will share successful cases where this method is already transforming transportation, electrification, and AI.

IMAGE CREDITS:WORLD BUSINESS FORUM

What to Think About Now If You Want to IPO Someday

Mo Jomaa, Partner, Capital G

From market considerations to unit economics, sales and marketing strategies, and executive hiring, it's never too early to think critically about how to build a business with the potential for an eventual public debut. Gain insights from [Mo Jomaa](#), a partner at Alphabet's independent growth fund, CapitalG, and investor in Databricks, Armis, Cribl, Grafana, and more, to learn what kinds of metrics growth-stage investors look for and how those metrics translate into eventual public market readiness. Discover actionable advice, whether an IPO is a year or a decade away.

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